



SADHUS AT A PROTEST; CHOUHAN (BELOW)

A Matter of FAITH

The Chouhan Government's move to appease a seer known to be close to the Congress has upset many sadhus who have traditionally supported the BJP

By Ambreesh Mishra

It's a sparring match featuring the most unlikely combatants. In one corner is Shankaracharya Swami Swaroopanand Saraswati, the popular seer from the Mahakoshal region. In the other is the BJP Government led by Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan. The third entity comprises thousands of sadhus and pujaris who are demanding an umbrella law to streamline the management of temples and mutts

and the vast properties they control.

When it acquiesced to the Shankaracharya recently, the Chouhan Government managed to avoid a stand-off with the seer. Barely a couple of days after taking a tough stance over the expansion of the Shankaracharya's ashram near the ancient structure of Sankla Gufa in Narsinghpur district of Mahakoshal, Forest Minister Sartaj Singh backtracked and approached the Dwarika-Sharda Peeth Shankaracharya to resolve the dispute. The reconciliation hardly pleased the

followers of Dandiswami Mohananand Saraswati, head of government-appointed advisory board for temples and mutts, who is perceived to be close to the BJP, while the Government keeps pleasing a seer who is seen as Congress-leaning.

"The Government bent over backwards to accommodate Swami Swaroopanandji's wishes. When the sadhus and pujaris had gathered to demand a just deal a couple of years ago, they were thrashed by the police in front of the chief minister's house,"

